

2, The Characteristics of the Expansionary Wars During the Western Han Period

Playing an even greater role than natural disasters were the wars. It is not difficult to discover that the foreign wars during Emperor Wu's reign possessed the following characteristics:

First, the operational range of the Han army was staggeringly vast. Today's Ulaanbaatar (乌兰巴托) in Mongolia (near the original location of the Chanyu's Court / 单于庭) and Hue (顺化) in Vietnam (the southernmost point of the Western Han expansion) are basically situated on the same meridian, yet they are separated by 3,500 kilometers north to south. Fergana (费尔干纳) in Central Asia (the location of the Dayuan state / 大宛国) and the eastern coast of Korea (the easternmost point of the Western Han expansion) are essentially on the same latitude, separated by 4,700 kilometers east to west.

Across such a colossal territorial expanse, the environments and inhabited ethnic groups were wildly disparate. Such military achievements were scarcely imaginable over two millennia ago. Among all empires prior to the modern era, only the conquest range of the Mongol Empire could surpass it; Rome and the Han Dynasty operated on the same level.

Second, predicated upon the already massive operational range of the Han army, another notable point is that many of the territories conquered by the Han forces were regions Chinese armies had never before set foot in, and were not even discovered and recognized by the Chinese until the era of Emperor Wu.

This implies that the Han Empire's expansion closely followed the footsteps of geographical discovery, sometimes even conquering first and discovering later. This characteristic clearly distinguishes it from many great empires, particularly Rome. Today, we realize that although the territories conquered by the Romans were vast, the majority of the territories during Rome's zenith were already known in previous eras. Ancient Greeks certainly knew of the Levant, Egypt, North Africa, Mesopotamia, and Spain, and even had some understanding of Britain; the Romans themselves had knowledge of Gaul before conquering it. Before Alexander conquered Persia, the Greeks and Persians had interacted for nearly two centuries. Even for the earlier Persian Empire, the civilizations of the Near East (近东) possessed considerable mutual understanding; Assyria, at least, was jointly annihilated by Babylon and Media.

This was even more true for the Mongols. Before the Mongol Empire conquered the vast regions of the Eurasian continent, trade networks connecting the entire continent had existed for over a millennium, various religions were widely disseminated within them, and more than one conqueror had rampaged between East and West. Therefore, when the Mongols decided to conquer a regime, they could entirely gather sufficient information through intelligence reconnaissance before taking action.

It is precisely under this contrast that the rapid military expansion of the Han Empire appears especially exceptional: it simultaneously possessed the dual natures of conquest and exploration. This nature of "*Zhaokong*" (凿空 - Piercing the Void) is highly similar to the expansion of European nations during the Age of Discovery.

Third, after conquering new frontiers, the Han Empire frequently carried out migrations on an unprecedented scale. As previously mentioned, the number of such migrants recorded in official histories alone was no less than 1.5 million. In fact, in the 2nd century BCE, government-led population relocation on such a scale was a historical first.

Migrating to the frontiers enabled the empire to swiftly control the newly conquered regions and anchor the institutional systems of the interior (内地) locally. Consequently, within a very short time, the conquered territories transformed into launching pads for new conquests. This forged a distinct difference from those empires that merely sought loose control, or lacked sufficient populations of their own ethnicity to migrate, satisfying themselves merely with the conquered peoples acknowledging their suzerainty.

Fourth, the fruits of conquest were also extremely astonishing by the standards of the time.

The expanded territories included most of Gansu, Ningxia, the Hehuang region (河湟地区), most of Inner Mongolia, Guizhou, parts of the Sichuan region, most of Yunnan, Fujian, Guangdong, Guangxi, Hainan, north-central Vietnam, and north-central Korea. Emperor Wu similarly established effective military deterrence and presence in the Xinjiang region; Xinjiang being incorporated into the Chinese map was merely one kick away. The vast majority of these newly conquered territories remain within China's borders today, and although Vietnam and Korea later became independent, they were consistently and strongly influenced by China.

Beyond these regions that can be considered direct territory, after achieving strategic initiative in counterattacking the Xiongnu (匈奴), Emperor Wu significantly crossed the Qin Great Wall to establish a massive military early-warning and defense system much further north, which simultaneously existed as a fulcrum for offensives. Further north, penetrating deep into the Xiongnu heartland of Mobei (漠北 / north of the Gobi Desert), there were Han military strongholds thrusting in like sharp knives—these were the Outer Great Walls (外长城) and the network of fortresses beyond the frontiers (塞外列城).

Modern archaeological work has already discovered several former Western Han military fortresses in the upper reaches of the Kherlen River (克鲁伦河) in today's Töv Province (中央省) of Mongolia; some were continuously used until the Liao and Jin dynasties. These fortresses were a mere hundred kilometers from the Chanyu's Court prior to the Battle of Mobei, which is exceedingly close for cavalry.

Obviously, it was precisely these military strongholds established after the decisive victory in Mobei that forced the Xiongnu during the mid-reign of Emperor Wu to relocate their ruling center westward—from the highly optimal environment of Ulaanbaatar to the vicinity of the later Uliastai (乌里雅苏台). Although this retreat forced the Han army to march significantly longer distances into the Gobi Desert during the next phase of operations—thus frequently suffering defeats—the Xiongnu's own power was drastically weakened as their operational range was massively reduced, ultimately leading to their fragmentation.

Maintaining a military presence in the heart of Mongolia is a feat whose extraordinary nature can only be appreciated when combined with China's own history. After the Western Han, the next dynasty capable of maintaining a military presence garrisoned by court armies on the Mongolian Plateau was the Liao Dynasty (辽朝)—a regime established by the Khitans (契丹) that occupied merely a small fraction of China's *Handi* in the north; yet its dynastic history is also regarded as one of the Twenty-Four Histories.

Moreover, the Liao people's strategy for ruling Mobei was exactly identical to that of the Han Dynasty: similarly tracing the Kherlen River westward from the east, building cities and garrisoning them, extending west until today's central region of Mongolia west of Ulaanbaatar (seemingly

slightly deeper than the Han period), because this was a region with a well-developed water system in the upper reaches of the Selenge River (色楞格河). The one after that was the Qing Empire (清帝国), which entirely ruled Khalkha Mongolia (喀尔喀蒙古) by relying on outstanding political maneuvers and the utilization of technological advancements; but the Qing Dynasty was similarly a regime established by an ethnic minority.

However, this military presence, which appeared far too ahead of its time, indeed imposed a heavy burden on state finances. During the reign of Emperor Xuan of Han (汉宣帝), the Han Dynasty's ultimate victory in this century-long war against the Xiongnu had become a foregone conclusion. Consequently, the military defense lines were massively withdrawn southward, and the network of fortresses beyond the frontiers subsequently ceased to be held by the Han court.

Fifth, the multi-tiered, elongated border defense system in Northern China and the Mongolian region during the mid-Western Han reveals a major characteristic of the war against the Xiongnu. Namely, under the premise of an extremely vast operational range, the "single front" (单一战线) of the war against the Xiongnu was also horrifyingly long. *(Of course, this could not be a front line of close contact between two armies like in modern warfare, but it was indeed a line where combat could erupt at any point, with both sides existing in a prolonged state of war).*

Currently, it is believed that the Han Great Wall (the Outer Great Wall constructed during Emperor Wu's reign), extending all the way from northern Korea to the border of Xinjiang and Gansu, had a total length exceeding 10,000 kilometers. Considering that some areas did not face the threat of the Xiongnu (such as Liaodong), that the Great Wall was divided into inner and outer lines in many sections, and that military fortresses existed beyond the Wall, the actual length of the control line where the Han Empire and the Xiongnu engaged in confrontation was considerably shorter.

But even so, during the 40 years from the mid-reign of Emperor Wu to Emperor Xuan's retraction of the defense lines, there existed a military confrontation line of at least 3,000 kilometers between the Han and the Xiongnu, located far away (800 to 900 kilometers) from the Han capital of Chang'an (长安). *(Outside the Han border defense system, wars between the Han and the Xiongnu would also erupt in places with only a small, scattered Han military presence, such as in Xinjiang).* And the war never ceased.

The straight-line distance between the western and eastern ends of this front exceeded 2,000 kilometers, which is longer than the straight-line distance from Berlin to Moscow. The length of the military confrontation line was also longer than the front line between the two nations in the Soviet-German War (苏德战争), and it lasted far longer. Such an elongated military confrontation line required million-level military personnel to garrison. No matter how much the borderlands were reclaimed and utilized, they could not possibly achieve self-sufficiency. Therefore, this inevitably imposed a colossal burden on state finances.

In reality, from the perspective of China's entire history, the number of Han Chinese population in the northern frontier regions of the Western Han was indeed anomalously large. One can easily realize this simply from the number and density of administrative divisions in that region. Along the Inner Mongolian section of the Han Great Wall, after the end of the Western Han, the number of Han residents did not surpass the Western Han level until after the "Zou Xikou" (走西口 / Westward Migration beyond the Great Wall) during the Qing Dynasty—which was nearly 2,000 years after the Han-Xiongnu War.

Sixth, the scale of the war was unprecedented, especially considering the ratio of the participating population to the total population of the Han Dynasty.

During Emperor Wu's reign, the military forces committed against the Xiongnu—including field armies and border defense forces—recorded in historical texts approached 2 million person-times (200 万人次). The number of people serving the war logistically could only be far greater. The troops the empire committed within a short timeframe were even more staggering. In the five years from 112 BCE to 108 BCE, the Han army successively deployed troops across five strategic directions: Nanyue (南越 / southeast), Western Qiang (西羌 / west), Eastern Yue (东越 / southeast), Xiongnu (匈奴 / north), Southwestern Barbarians (西南夷 / southwest), and Joseon (朝鲜 / northeast).

Except for the Xiongnu Chanyu who dared not engage in battle, the other five directions were all conquered. During these five years, nearly 1.5 million troops were deployed. This meant that 5% of the nation's total population directly participated in military operations—a feat unimaginable for an agricultural empire two millennia ago.

Setting aside civil wars during periods of division, it was not until the War of Resistance Against Japanese Aggression (抗日战争) in the last century that China's military mobilization rate (军事动员率) surpassed that of the Han-Xiongnu War for the first time. *(If we calculate based on the population within China's legal territory at the time, it might not even match the Western Han. However, considering that the War of Resistance was a defensive war and a massive portion of China's population was in Japanese-occupied zones, the mobilization rate of the population actually controlled by the Nationalist Government was indeed higher than that of the Han era. Furthermore, during Emperor Wu's reign, the Chinese army was accustomed to fighting outside its borders and turning those foreign lands into new territories).*

Merely considering the troops deployed by the Han army in a single campaign is astonishing enough. For example, in the campaign to conquer Joseon, the General of the Towered Ships, Yang Pu (楼船将军杨仆), led 50,000 troops from Shandong across the Bohai Sea to land in Joseon. In the entirety of ancient China, there was never another cross-sea military operation that achieved its campaign objectives with a troop strength surpassing the Han's war to annihilate Joseon. The next successful cross-sea campaign exceeding this troop strength was the Liberation of Hainan Island (解放海南岛), over 2,000 years later.

(The Zizhi Tongjian / 《资治通鉴》 claims that Su Dingfang [苏定方] led an army of 100,000 from Weihai across the sea, landing at the mouth of the Ungjin River [熊津江口] to unite with Silla [新罗] and annihilate Baekje [百济]. However, neither the Biography of Su Dingfang nor the Biographies of the Eastern Barbarians in the Old Book of Tang [《旧唐书》] contains records of troop strength, and the same absence occurs in the New Book of Tang [《新唐书》]. Later, when China and Japan fought at the Battle of Baekgang [白江口作战], it is explicitly recorded that 7,000 reinforcements were dispatched from Shandong. Based on the context of Tang troop deployments before and after this event, there is ample reason to believe that the record of 100,000 troops lacks any factual basis.)

Even before the navy was capable of undertaking cross-sea operations, Emperor Wu had already attached extreme importance to the inland river navy, to the extent of excavating the Kunming Pool (昆明池) south of Chang'an specifically to train naval forces. In the war to subjugate Nanyue (南越),

the emperor "ordered the Yue people and a tower-ship force of 100,000 from south of the Jianghuai to go forth and suppress it" (令粤人及江淮以南楼船十万师往讨之).

After conquering the two Yue regions (Nanyue and Dongyue), the Chinese Empire had incorporated all territories reachable by inland river navigation into its own borders. From then on, aside from battles that decided the fate of the realm during times of chaos—like the Battle of Lake Poyang (鄱阳湖大战)—the court no longer needed, nor was it possible, to build such a colossal inland river navy again.

The same held true for military operations in the North. Twenty years after the decisive Battle of Mobei, the Han Dynasty once again dispatched Li Guangli (李广利) and others to lead an army of 210,000 on a northern expedition against the Xiongnu. The troop strength even exceeded that of the Battle of Mobei (*however, the number of cavalry decreased, and the vast majority deployed this time were infantry, which illustrates the immense attrition caused by the war*). In the entire campaign, the total forces committed by both sides exceeded 310,000 (*as the troop strength of the Xiongnu's Worthy Prince of the Left / 左贤王 is unrecorded*).

This campaign, which primarily occurred at the Yuwu River (余吾水), became the largest main-force pitched battle in history to take place in the heart of the Mongolian Plateau. Even when Genghis Khan initially unified the various Mongol tribes, his total tribal followers numbered no more than 100,000.

Military operations in the Western Regions (西域) were even more extreme. Take Li Guangli's war to defeat Dayuan (大宛) as an example. The Han army that reached the capital of Dayuan numbered 30,000, while the army that set out from Dunhuang numbered 60,000. To support this distant expedition, an additional 200,000 people were conscripted for logistics. These figures are exceptionally high even among Central Plains dynasties undertaking military operations in the Western Regions. The Tang Dynasty's troops in the Western Regions were far short of 60,000, relying primarily on mobilizing forces from vassal states during combat. When the Tang army in the Western Regions fought the Arabs at the Battle of Talas (怛罗斯之战), the total allied forces on the Tang side did not exceed 30,000.

Further down the timeline, during the Qing Dynasty, when Emperor Qianlong pacified the Dzungars and the Hui (平准平回), and when Zuo Zongtang (左宗棠) recovered Xinjiang, the troop strengths deployed by the Qing army still did not surpass the Han Dynasty's war against Dayuan. The above only accounts for the Han side; judging from the fact that the Xiongnu could still regroup and stage comebacks in multiple pitched battles, it is no exaggeration to say that the Xiongnu people were engaged in a "total war" (全民战争).

Seventh, the war between the Han and the Xiongnu was immensely protracted. During Emperor Wu's reign, starting from the Ambush at Mayi (马邑之谋), the two nations engaged in combat for over 40 years. If calculated up to 36 BCE when the Northern Xiongnu Chanyu Zhizhi (郅支单于) was killed, nearly a century had passed. From the late Western Han to the mid-Eastern Han, when the Northern Xiongnu finally fled far away, more than another century elapsed. If we trace it back to the early Han Dynasty when the Han army and the Xiongnu first engaged in combat, the war between the Han and Xiongnu regimes lasted for three centuries.

However, it must be pointed out that this prolonged conflict did not obstruct interactions between the two sides; the elongated line of confrontation was not an impenetrable wall of iron and brass. Emperor Wu's reign served as the turning point and peak of the Han-Xiongnu War. Although warfare was the overwhelmingly dominant form of interaction, it was precisely the war itself that brought about intense exchanges of personnel and materials.

Emperor Wu's reign was the period with the highest number of personnel crossing over to the opposing state, either through capture or voluntary surrender. From historical records, we can clearly note that both the Han Empire and the Xiongnu attached great importance to personnel from the enemy state who surrendered to them, invariably providing them with sincere and generous treatment. We can, of course, view this as a propaganda offensive, but in reality, these surrendered personnel indeed performed a great deal of work; some even directly led armies to fight against their former homelands, with Li Ling (李陵) being the most famous among them.

For the populace in the border regions of both nations, the situation was even more complex. For example, Zhao Ponu (赵破奴) was originally a native of Jiuyuan, but he fled to the Xiongnu in his youth, later returning to the Han to fight as a Han general. After being defeated and captured in one battle, he lived among the Xiongnu for another ten years before returning to the Han. Wei Lü (卫律) was originally a Hu (胡) barbarian from Changshui who served the Han Dynasty. However, out of fear of being implicated in a political incident within the Han palace, he surrendered to the Xiongnu, became the chieftain of the Dingling (丁零) tribe, and, due to his identity as a Hu who understood the Han, became a crucial chief strategist (谋主) for the Xiongnu.

As for someone like Zhao Xin (赵信), he simply surrendered twice: first surrendering from the Xiongnu to the Han to fight for the Han, and then surrendering once again to the Xiongnu.

Upon surrendering, generals from both sides would bring crucial military intelligence. The Xiongnu could provide the Han with geographical information and knowledge of cavalry warfare (though, of course, direct participation in combat was the primary contribution). Conversely, the Han helped the Xiongnu train their troops—a fact that is invariably easy to overlook.

It should be pointed out that high-ranking Han defectors like Li Ling (李陵), who held immense power after surrendering to the Xiongnu, were highly effective in training the Xiongnu forces. For instance, in the final battle where the Xiongnu routed Li Guangli's (李广利) army, the Xiongnu actually approached the Han military camp at night by digging sapping trenches (挖壕沟), subsequently launching a surprise attack from the rear of the Han army to secure victory.

This method of approaching enemy defensive fortifications by excavating trenches was widely utilized in military operations right up to the last century. The fact that the Xiongnu won this battle—which ultimately forced Emperor Wu to issue the *Luntai Edict* (《轮台诏》 / *Edict of Repentance at Luntai*)—amply demonstrates the effectiveness of the training provided by surrendered Han generals and the extremely strong learning capacity of the Xiongnu. It was precisely this uninterrupted, mutual learning through warfare that allowed the disadvantaged party to always counterbalance the opponent's advantages to a certain extent, thereby prolonging the war even further.

Aside from battlefield captives and surrenders, the mutual dispatch of envoys by both sides also never experienced long-term interruption. Moreover, in the diplomatic processes between the two regimes, both sides regarded each other as peer competitors.

For example, during the period following the decisive Battle of Mobei, the Xiongnu were recovering, while the Han army was busy constructing an increasing number of fortresses further north, leading to a temporary halt in large-scale military operations. During this brief interwar period, envoys were frequently exchanged between the two nations. Even as the defeated party in the preceding phase of the war, the Xiongnu strenuously maintained their dignity and pursued parity in diplomacy. For instance, if a Han envoy refused to lay down his imperial credentials (符节) and paint his face with ink (墨涂面), he was denied entry into the Chanyu's great tent.

Simultaneously, when the two sides detained each other's envoys, they also pursued a tit-for-tat parity: if you detain one of my men, I will inevitably detain one of yours. After the concept of the Huaxia (华夏) community formed during the Zhou Dynasty, and before the prolonged war between the Han and the Xiongnu, the Huaxia people actually lacked an enemy possessing sufficient strength to demand parity. Consequently, the Huaxia could always contemptuously dismiss the surrounding foreign tribes as various *barbarians* (蛮夷戎狄 / Man, Yi, Rong, Di).

The Han-Xiongnu war forced this situation to undergo a transformation. Years of confrontation with the "**Other**" (他者) enhanced self-awareness on both sides. The war catalyzed cultural identification within both nations, especially for the Han people as the victors who turned the tide.

Today, when we examine the history of the Han-Xiongnu war, we must, on one hand, acknowledge that to win this war that determined the destiny of the state, the Han Empire drastically depleted *Minli* (people's physical capacity and labor / 民力), to the extent that Emperor Wu had to conscript massive numbers of convicts in his later years.

But on the other hand, it is hard not to notice that at the time, an extraordinary patriotic enthusiasm indeed existed among Han intellectuals. The most quintessential evidence is that ever since conflicts with the Xiongnu became increasingly frequent, names brimming with patriotic sentiment like "Ponü" (破奴 - Smashing the Xiongnu) and "Anguo" (安国 - Securing the State) became symbols of an era.

Furthermore, every time the court launched a distant expedition against the Xiongnu or other enemies, no matter how treacherous the journey, it could not deter "those who followed with private provisions" (负私从者)—that is, private citizens bringing their own grain to follow the army and participate in the war. Whether one calls these people patriotic, or—as is certainly more likely—they were simply fighting for military merit (军功), considering that Emperor Wu's unsparing generosity in rewarding military merit was known to all under heaven.

Regardless, all of this illustrates that due to the specific social conditions of the mid-Western Han, the Han Empire's military expansion consistently possessed a certain foundation of public support. This is precisely why, despite undertaking military mobilizations of such colossal personnel scale across such vast distances, and despite there being generals who surrendered after defeat, there were exceedingly few mutinying soldiers (哗变的士卒).

Eighth, the war between the Han and the Xiongnu was reflected not only in its scale, scope, and duration, but it also brought about a thorough revolution in the military affairs of all of East Asia.

This permeated almost every aspect of the military, including weapons, military technology, troop types, tactics, military systems, and strategy. This transformation aligns with general military logic: the more intense the military conflict, the larger its scale, and the longer its duration, the more profound the resulting military innovations will inevitably be.

During this war, certain weapons and equipment that had occupied prominent positions in Chinese cultural imagery were rendered obsolete, represented by the dagger-axe (*Ge* / 戈) and the war chariot (战车). Meanwhile, new iconic weapons entered the historical stage, represented by the ring-pommel sword (*Huanshou Dao* / 环首刀) and the Han crossbow (*Han Nu* / 汉弩).

To adapt to different enemies in diverse regions, the Han army had to employ new technologies to improve its armaments. For example, during the conquest of the South, facing the Yue (越) people's proficiency in diving, the warships of the Han inland river navy had to be equipped with devices to prevent underwater sabotage. Conversely, to combat the Xiongnu army, which excelled at horseback archery on the northern steppes, the Han's own cavalry had to be equipped with more practical riding gear. Based on the historical fact that the Han Dynasty employed large-scale cavalry shock charges, there is ample reason to believe that stirrups (马镫) and high saddles (高马鞍) had already seen a certain degree of use.

The most crucial military technological innovation, however, was the popularization of iron. During Emperor Wu's reign, the Chinese Empire's iron smelting technology (especially blast furnace iron smelting / 高炉炼铁), alongside the quality and output of iron, experienced a massive elevation. Iron weapons became fundamentally ubiquitous, and the defensive and lethal capabilities of the army visibly ascended to a new level. As the representative of Han iron weapons, the Han sword (*Han Jian* / 汉剑) not only became an essential weapon for troops in combat but also began to play an increasingly significant role in Chinese culture. Male aristocrats wearing swords became a fashion, and even a symbol of status and rank.

Fighting a cavalry-dominated Xiongnu army on Xiongnu territory required the Han army to possess commensurate mobility. Thus, through the military practice of two outstanding commanders, Wei Qing (卫青) and Huo Qubing (霍去病), the tactics of large-scale cavalry corps operations (骑兵大兵团作战) matured. Now, the Chinese army could deploy cavalry to win a decisive pitched battle, rather than relegating cavalry to a mere supporting role in warfare.

Furthermore, the victorious counterattacks against the Xiongnu also altered the Han Dynasty's long-standing shortage of horses. At the foot of today's Qilian Mountains (祁连山), the Han Empire acquired the highest quality and largest-scale military horse breeding ground in Chinese history, known today as the Shandan Horse Farm (山丹军马场). Ever since Emperor Wu conquered this region up to the present day, it has remained one of the largest sources of premium warhorses in the entire world. The increase in animal power brought immense improvements to Han military logistics. Later, when Li Guangli (李广利) campaigned against Dayuan (大宛), Emperor Wu equipped him with a logistical transport fleet composed of over a hundred thousand cattle, horses, donkeys, and camels.

In addition to cavalry entering the historical stage as a primary troop type, the navy played a role in the military conquest of the South during Emperor Wu's reign equivalent to that of the cavalry in the North. Even more remarkably, the Han Empire was not satisfied with merely using a navy to control inland river navigation; instead, it boldly commanded it to venture into the ocean, achieving military glory in the war to conquer Joseon (朝鲜). Benefiting from the development of shipbuilding technology, the Chinese Empire, for the first time in its history, (partially) controlled a large island beyond the mainland: Hainan Island (海南岛).

In order to still command a powerful military force directly subordinate to the emperor amidst frequent military deployments, Emperor Wu established the Eight Colonels (*Ba Xiaowei* / 八校尉). This marked the beginning of the *mercenary/recruitment system* (募兵制) in the Han Dynasty, signifying a further elevation in the professionalization of the Chinese military.

Finally, a crucial outcome of the Han Empire's military expansion was that, for the first time, the Chinese people grasped the topographical formations and political regime distributions within a radius of several thousand kilometers surrounding their inhabited lands. This enabled China, for the first time since its unification, to formulate a **grand national strategy** (国家战略).

Even today, people can still discern Emperor Wu's extraordinary strategic vision from China's current administrative divisions and historical events subsequent to the Han Dynasty.

During Emperor Wu's reign, the most vital strategic doctrine and legacy were directed against the formidable northern enemy, the Xiongnu—a strategy that held profound historical significance throughout the entire ancient period. Targeting the natural conditions of the Mongolian Plateau—which is higher in the west and lower in the east, colder in the west and warmer in the east, and drier in the west while wetter in the east—the Han army focused the brunt of its counteroffensive on the east. They dealt a devastating blow to the Xiongnu's heartland and constructed military defensive fortresses in the upper reaches of the Kherlen River.

In executing this, Emperor Wu paid immense attention to dividing the northern *Hu* (胡) barbarians, particularly separating the nomadic tribes in the heart of the Mongolian Plateau from those on its eastern fringes, namely the Eastern Hu (*Donghu* / 东胡). While ordering Huo Qubing to smash the Xiongnu's Left Territory, he simultaneously applied a policy of conciliation and appeasement (怀柔政策) toward the Eastern Hu ethnic groups headed by the Wuhuan (乌桓). He established the Colonel Protector of the Wuhuan (*Hu Wuhuan Xiaowei* / 护乌桓校尉) to govern the Wuhuan who had submitted internally (内附), and specifically demanded "*that they must not be allowed to communicate or interact with the Xiongnu*" (使其不得与匈奴交通).

Emperor Wu's policy of drawing close to the Eastern Hu exerted a profound impact on the history of the Chinese Empire. Over the next four centuries or so, the nomadic tribes on the eastern edge of Mongolia—the Wuhuan and Xianbei (鲜卑)—maintained an intimate relationship with the Han-ethnicity court. Although wars were not entirely absent, they appeared as allies the vast majority of the time. Even at the onset of the massive northern chaos at the end of the Western Jin Dynasty, the Wuhuan and Xianbei in the northeast still regarded the Eastern Jin regime (which had just retreated to Jiangzuo) as an ally, and proceeded to attack the Xiongnu led by Liu Yuan (刘渊) and the Jie (羯) barbarians subordinated to Shi Le (石勒). Once the ethnic minorities of Mongolia and the Northeast

united, or a single ethnicity occupied both regions, their threat would multiply exponentially. The histories of the Xianbei and the Manchus (满洲人) fully prove this point.

Meanwhile, to the west of Mongolia, Emperor Wu also realized the colossal danger posed by a union between the ethnic minorities of the Mongolian Plateau and the Tibetan Plateau (青藏高原). He resolutely executed the strategic policy of **"isolating the Qiang from the Hu"** (隔绝羌胡). He conquered the Hexi Corridor (河西走廊) and the Hehuang region, subsequently marching massive armies into Xinjiang, thereby forming an encircling posture against the Xiongnu in reverse.

Throughout all historical periods, this strategy held monumental significance for stabilizing the western frontiers of the Chinese Empire. During Emperor Wu's time, there was no powerful regime in the heart of the Tibetan Plateau, and the Qiang people primarily operated on the plateau's eastern fringes. It was not until seven centuries later, with the rapid rise of the Tibetan Empire (吐蕃帝国), that Emperor Wu's strategic vision spanned the long years to reveal its extraordinary value.

At the absolute zenith of Tibetan power, Li Bi (李泌), a renowned minister of the mid-Tang Dynasty, proposed a strategy of diplomatic liaison with the nations surrounding Tibet, particularly advocating an alliance with the Uyghurs (回纥) who had already occupied the northern steppes, to jointly counter Tibet. This strategy achieved monumental success. It fostered mutual hostility between the regimes of the Mongolian Plateau and the Tibetan Plateau, ensured the relative stability of the Tang Dynasty's frontiers, curbed Tibetan expansion, and ultimately dragged down this massive plateau empire.

In contrast, Mongolia during the Ming and Qing dynasties became a counter-example of what happens when this strategy is not well executed. In the 17th century, using Tibetan Buddhism (藏传佛教) as a nexus, the connections between various Mongol tribes and Tibet grew increasingly intimate. Ultimately, a powerful Tibetan Buddhist Khanate (i.e., the Dzungar Khanate) formed in western China, posing a severe threat to the Qing Dynasty. When the Qing Empire finally pacified its western frontiers after decades of effort spanning three emperors, it had no choice but to re-examine the wisdom of the Han Empire from two millennia prior.

Even today, the long and narrow province of Gansu (甘肃)—primarily populated by Han Chinese—stretches across and physically separates the four autonomous regions of Xinjiang, Tibet, Ningxia, and Inner Mongolia, completely isolating the former two from the latter two geographically. Its political significance is entirely self-evident.

Ninth, the Han Dynasty's foreign wars brought about more than just military victories. Aside from annexing enemies and expanding territory, the most crucial benefit of Han military expansion lay in the Han people discovering and opening up routes of interaction with the outside world.

Ancient East Asia possessed a total of four major trade routes connecting to the outside world. The northernmost route traversed the Eurasian Steppe westward from the Mongolian Plateau, stringing together this massive nomadic region. Its zenith was naturally the era of the Mongol conquests—the most glorious years of the Mongol Empire's capital, Karakorum (哈拉和林). This is known as the Steppe Silk Road (草原丝绸之路).

The second route exited modern China's borders via the Hexi Corridor in Gansu and along the foothills of the east-west mountain ranges in Xinjiang, reaching Central Asia, and then connecting to the further West via Iran. This is what is now commonly called the Silk Road (丝绸之路).

The third route set sail from China's southeastern coast southward into the sea. Initially, it turned into the Gulf of Siam (暹罗湾) and crossed the Isthmus of Kra (克拉地峡). With advancements in navigation and shipbuilding technology, by the Tang Dynasty, it had evolved to pass through the Strait of Malacca into the Indian Ocean, reaching India, and even further to the Persian Gulf, the Red Sea, and the coast of East Africa. This is what is now commonly called the Maritime Silk Road (海上丝绸之路).

The fourth route consists of the corridors connecting southern Chinese regions like Sichuan, Yunnan, and Tibet to the outside world at various historical periods, represented by the Shu-Shendu Road (蜀身毒道 / Sichuan-India Road) and the Tea Horse Road (茶马古道). Today, this is referred to as the Southwestern Silk Road (西南丝绸之路).

Because China could not establish stable rule over the Mobei plateau prior to the Qing Dynasty, and by the time of the Qing, the Eurasian Steppe had declined and the Steppe Silk Road had ceased to exist, its significance to the Chinese Empire was extremely limited.

Of the remaining three external corridors that the Chinese Empire could control, both the overland Silk Road and the Maritime Silk Road were opened up during Emperor Wu's reign through foreign wars and diplomatic activities. The starting point of the latter back then was located in modern-day Xuwen (徐闻), Guangdong Province—known in the Han Dynasty as Hepu Commandery (合浦郡), which was territory of the Nanyue Kingdom (南越国) before being conquered by the Han Empire.

As for the third, relatively less important Southwestern Silk Road, although it was not considered fully connected until the Ailao (哀牢) people *submitted internally* (内附) during the Eastern Han Dynasty, through Emperor Wu's subjugation of the Southwestern Barbarians (西南夷) and the Han Empire's road construction in the southwest region (represented by the Bonan Trail / 博南道), its ultimate incorporation into the Chinese Empire's control was merely a matter of time.

Therefore, we can say that out of the three external trade corridors meaningful to Central Plains dynasties, Emperor Wu's military conquests transformed the two most important ones into reality and laid the foundation for the opening of the relatively secondary third one.

Beyond the main routes leading to the major parts of the western Eurasian continent, the Han Empire's conquest of Joseon in the northeast and its frequent naval patrols promoted communication and development in the Northeast Asian region. The *Treatise on Geography in the Book of Han* (《汉书地理志》) mentions that beyond the seas of Lelang Commandery (乐浪郡), there were the Wa people (倭人) who frequently came to pay tribute (朝贡). This is the first recorded interaction between China and Japan, which subsequently became increasingly common. In fact, archaeology also indicates that the Qin and Han periods were the critical era when wet-rice cultivation technology was rapidly disseminated across the Japanese archipelago, leading to swift progress in Japanese society.

The establishment of connections with the outside world not only more than doubled the known world of the Chinese people but also brought tremendous progress to China. Taking the Maritime Silk Road alone as an example, in order to conquer the turbulent South China Sea, a series of great

maritime inventions were born during the Han Dynasty, including the balanced lugsail (平衡式梯形斜帆), the yuloh (船櫓 / scull or sweep), and the sternpost rudder (船舵).

Simultaneously, driven by the needs of positioning and maritime observation, related mathematical methods also emerged during the Han Dynasty. In the *Haidao Suanjing* (《海岛算经》 / *The Sea Island Mathematical Manual*) written by the Chinese mathematician Liu Hui (刘徽) during the Wei-Jin period, many mathematical problems originated from maritime navigation.

In reality, although East Asia—blocked by plateaus and mountain ranges—was only a relatively secondary part of the Eurasian continent, the scientific (including mathematical) creations born in China indeed reached their zeniths, both in quality and quantity, during two specific periods. The first was the roughly 200 years of the two Han dynasties; the second was the period of the Song, Jin, and Yuan empires. The common characteristic of these two periods was highly frequent foreign exchange, especially compared to preceding eras.

Undoubtedly, China's military conquests during Emperor Wu's reign were not merely about expanding territory; they were equally a process of China discovering, experiencing, and embracing the world.

Tenth, although the distinction between civil and military officials was not yet pronounced throughout the Han Dynasty, we can still note that despite undertaking foreign wars of such magnitude during the mid-Western Han, the central government consistently maintained firm control over the military.

Unlike many conquering empires, Emperor Wu did not take the field to personally lead campaigns (御驾亲征) while undertaking the enterprise of expanding territory and repelling barbarians (拓土攘夷). The only time he arrayed an army of 180,000 to march north and invite the Chanyu to a decisive battle was more of a demonstration of power; in reality, it was impossible for the Chanyu to actually show up and ask for such a humiliation.

Although Emperor Wu conducted numerous imperial inspection tours, his primary destinations were not the frontier territories he had newly conquered. In his youth, the emperor frequently led his retinue to hunt and engage in hand-to-hand combat. This hobby accompanied him throughout his life; in his later reign, he even watched *Juedi* (角抵 / ancient Chinese wrestling) alongside commoners. Living to the age of 70 under such high-intensity internal and external pressures is sufficient to prove that Emperor Wu was personally in excellent health.

Yet, the monarch of the Han Empire no longer needed to consolidate his rule by commanding in person on the battlefield or achieving military victories through the flaunting of martial valor. Therefore, we can say that the highest decision-makers of the empire directed this epoch-making war through the empire's *bureaucratic system* (官僚制度) from a court that was increasingly distant from the front lines (because the front lines were constantly pushing outward).

Simultaneously, although the war against the Xiongnu allowed many to reap military merit and subsequently obtain noble ranks, even a war of such duration and scale failed to produce a *military aristocracy* (军事贵族) group capable of exerting a decisive role in politics. The Han army remained consistently under the control of the central government, let alone being able to dictate the succession of the imperial throne like the Roman legions.

And the man who ultimately brought about the end of the Western Han, Wang Mang (王莽), did not rise from the military ranks. On the contrary, he was a great Confucian scholar with the status of an imperial relative by marriage (外戚 / consort kin). Supported by the bureaucrats, he ultimately usurped the emperor's throne through relatively peaceful means.

2, 西汉时期的扩张战争具有哪些特点

比自然灾害起到更大作用的是战争，我们不难发现武帝一朝的对外战争有如下特征：

第一，汉朝军队作战范围极大，如今蒙古的乌兰巴托（单于庭原先位置附近）与越南顺化（西汉扩张的最南端）基本位于同一经线上，而南北相距 3500 公里。中亚的费尔干纳（大宛国所在地）与朝鲜东海岸（西汉扩张的最东端）基本位于同一纬线上，而东西相距 4700 公里。如此庞大的地域范围中各地环境和居住的民族迥然不同，如此武功在两千多年前是难以想象的事情，在近代之前的所有帝国中只有蒙古帝国的征服范围能够超过，罗马与汉朝则处于同一水平。

第二，在汉军作战范围本身就大的前提下，另一个值得注意的事情是汉军所征讨的地域很多都是中国军队从未涉足过的，甚至是直到汉武帝的年代才被中国人所发现和认识的。这意味着汉帝国的扩张实际上是紧随地理发现脚步，有的时候甚至是先征服再发现。该特征与许多大帝国明显地区别开来，特别是罗马，我们今天发现罗马人所征服的范围虽然广大，但是罗马鼎盛时期大部分领土都是在前代已经被认知的。古代希腊人当然知道黎凡特、埃及、北非、美索不达米亚和西班牙甚至对不列颠也有一定了解，罗马人在征服高卢之前自己也高卢有认识。亚历山大征服波斯之前，希腊人和波斯人已经打了快两个世纪的交道，即使是对于更早的波斯帝国来说，近东各文明互相之间也有了相当的了解，至少亚述就是被巴比伦和米底联合消灭的。蒙古人的情况就更是如此了，在蒙古帝国征服欧亚大陆的广大地区之前，联通整个大陆的贸易网络已经出现了上千年之久，宗教各种广泛传播于其中，不止一个征服者曾横行于东西之间。所以当蒙古人决定征服一个政权的时候，他们完全可以通过情报侦查来获得足够的信息再采取行动。正是在这种对比之下汉帝国急速的军事扩张才显得尤为特殊，它同时具备了征服和探险两种性质，这种“凿空”的性质与地理大发现时期欧洲国家的扩张是相似的。

第三，汉帝国征服新的边疆之后往往会进行规模空前的移民，前面已经提到过仅仅是正史中记载这种移民的人数就不少于 150 万人，而事实上在公元前二世纪，由政府主导的如此规模的人口迁徙尚属首次。对边疆的移民使得帝国迅速地控制了新征服的地区，并且将内地的体制在当地固定下来，进而在很短的时间内被征服的领地就转变成为了新的征服的出发地。这就与那些仅仅追求松散控制或是没有足够的本族人口进行移民，满足于被征服者承认宗主权的帝国产生了明显的区别。

第四，征服的成果在当时看来也是极为惊人的，扩张的领土包括甘肃大部，宁夏，河湟地区，内蒙古大部，贵州，部分四川地区，云南大部，福建，广东，广西，海南，越南中北部，朝鲜中北部，汉武帝同样在新疆地区建立了有效的军事威慑和存在，新疆被纳入中国版图也仅差临门一脚。这些新征服的领土现在绝大多数仍然处于中国版图内，越南和朝鲜虽然后来独立却始终受到中国强烈影响。除了这些可以被视为领土的地区，汉武帝在反击匈奴取得战略主动之后，大大地跨过了秦长城在更北方的地方建立了规模庞大的军事预警和防御体系，同时也作为进攻的支点存在，而在更北处深入漠北匈奴腹地还有

作为尖刀一样刺入的汉军据点，这就是外长城及塞外列城。近现代的考古工作已经在克鲁伦河上游今天蒙古国中央省发现了数个西汉曾经的军事要塞，有的一直使用到辽金时期，这些要塞与漠北之战前的单于庭相距仅有百公里，对于骑兵而言已经相当接近。显然正是这些在漠北决战胜利之后设置的军事据点，迫使匈奴人在武帝统治中期将统治中心从环境最为优越的乌兰巴托西迁到后来的乌里雅苏台附近，这种退缩虽然使得汉军在下一个阶段作战时不得不进入戈壁沙漠行军更长的距离，因而时常被击败。但匈奴自身的力量也因活动范围被大幅削减而大为衰弱，并最终走向分裂。在蒙古的腹地维持军事存在这件事情只有结合中国自身的历史才能看出汉代的事业是多么非凡，自西汉以后，下一个能在蒙古高原由朝廷军队进行驻守维持军事存在的王朝是辽朝，一个契丹人建立的，仅仅占据中国北方一小部分汉地的政权，但是其王朝的断代史也被视为 24 史之一。而且辽人统治漠北的思路与汉代完全相同，那就是同样从东方溯克鲁伦河而上筑城而守，向西直到今天乌兰巴托以西的蒙古国中心地区（看来比汉代要略微深入），因为这是色楞格河上游水系发达的地区。而再下一个就是清帝国，它凭借出色的政治手段和对技术进步的利用完全统治了喀尔喀蒙古，但清朝同样也是一个少数民族建立的政权。然而这种看起来太过超前的军事存在的确给国家财政带来了很大负担，在汉宣帝统治时期，汉朝获得与匈奴之间这场长达百余年的战争的最终胜利已经成为定局，于是将军事防线大范围向后撤，塞外列城遂不为汉廷所有。

第五，西汉中叶在中国北方和蒙古地区多层次的漫长的边防体系揭示了汉代对匈奴战争中的一个重大特点，那就是在军事行动范围极广的前提下，对匈奴战争的单一战线（当然，这不可能是近现代军事中那样两军紧密接触的战线，但的确是任何一个点都有爆发战斗的可能，双方则长期处于交战状态）从长度上讲也相当骇人。现在认为汉长城（汉武帝时期所修的外长城）从朝鲜北部一直延伸到新疆和甘肃交界地总长超过了一万千米，考虑到有些地区并不面临匈奴的威胁（比如辽东），很多地段长城分为内外两条，以及长城以外尚有军事要塞存在，汉帝国与匈奴在控制线上进行对抗的长度要远远小得多。但即使如此，从汉武帝统治中期到宣帝收缩防线 40 年间，汉朝和匈奴之间至少存在远离汉朝首都长安

（800 到 900 千米）的 3000 公里长度的军事对峙线（在汉代边塞防御体系之外仅有分散少量驻军的地方汉朝和匈奴也会爆发战争，例如在新疆），而战争从来没有停歇过。这条战线的西头和东头直线距离超过了 2000 千米，比柏林到莫斯科的直线距离更长，而军事对峙线的长度也比苏德战争中两国的战线还长，并且持续的时间久得多。如此漫长的军事对峙线需要百万级别的军事人员进行驻防，而边地再怎么开垦利用也不可能自给自足，因此，必然给国家财政带来巨大的负担。实际上西汉北方边疆地区汉族人口的数量确从中国的整个历史来看多到反常，人们从该地区行政区划的数量和密度就很容易意识到这一点。在汉长城内蒙古段一线自西汉结束之后汉族居民的数量超过西汉水平已经到了清代走西口之后，这已经离汉匈战争过去了将近 2000 年。

第六，战争的规模是史无前例的，特别是考虑到参战人口和汉代总人口的比例而言。武帝一朝对匈奴投入的军事力量，包括野战军和边防军史书记载接近 200 万人次，为战争服务的人数只能更多。帝国在短时间内投入的兵力更加惊人，在公元前 112 年到公元前 108 年五年中，汉军相继对南越，西羌，东越，匈奴，西南夷，朝鲜五个战略方向上（东南，西，北，西南，东北）用兵，除匈奴单于不敢应战以外其余五方均被征服，而这五年间投入的兵力将近 150 万，这意味着全国 5% 的人口直接参与到了军事行动中，对于两千年前的农业帝国是难以想象的。抛开分裂时期的内战不谈，一直到上个世纪的抗日战争时期，中国的军事动员率才首次超过了汉匈战争（如果计算当年中国合法领土内的人口，甚至还比不上西汉，但是必须考虑到抗日战争是防御性的战争，当时中国大量人口处于日本占领区，那么国民政府能实控的人口动员率就已经比汉代高了。而汉武帝时期中国军队习惯于在境外作战并且把境外变成新的疆土）。仅仅考虑汉军在单次战役中投入的兵力也是惊人的，例如在征服朝鲜的战役中，楼船将军杨仆从

山东率兵五万渡过渤海在朝鲜登陆。而在整个古代中国就再也没有兵力超过汉灭朝鲜之战的最终达到战役目的的跨海军事行动了，下一次兵力超过这场战争的成功渡海战役就已经是 2000 多年后的解放海南岛。

（《资治通鉴》声称苏定方率领军队十万从威海出兵渡海在熊津江口登陆与新罗联合灭百济，但旧唐书中苏定方的传以及东夷传中均未有兵力记载，新唐书中同样无，后来中日两国在白江口作战明文记载从山东派出 7000 援兵。根据前后唐代出兵情况有充分理由认为十万的兵力记载没有任何依据）

而早在水军能够出海行动之前，汉武帝对于内河水军就已经极为重视，以至于长安城南开凿昆明池以训练水军。在讨伐南越的战争中，皇帝“令粤人及江淮以南楼船十万师往讨之”，征服两越之后，中华帝国已经把内河航运能够覆盖到的土地全部纳入自己的疆域中，至此除了乱世中像鄱阳湖大战这样的决定天下归属的战斗，朝廷已经不需要，也不可能再建设一支如此庞大的内河水军了。在北方的军事行动同样如此，漠北决战之后 20 年，汉朝又派李广利等率军 21 万北伐匈奴，兵力甚至超过了漠北决战

（但骑兵的数量变少了，这次投入的大多数都是步兵，由此可见战争消耗的巨大），整场战役中双方投入的总兵力超过 31 万（因为匈奴左贤王的兵力没有记载），这场主要发生在余吾水的战役成为历史上发生在蒙古高原腹地规模最大的主力会战，即使是成吉思汗最初统一蒙古各部的时候其部众也不过十万。对西域的军事行动就更是了，以李广利击败大宛一战为例，汉朝军队到达大宛国都的有三万人，而自敦煌而出的军队六万人，为了保障这次远征又征发了 20 万人。这些数字对于在西域用兵的中原王朝也是非常多的，唐朝在西域的军队远没有六万，作战时主要靠调集仆从国的部队，西域唐军与阿拉伯人在怛罗斯作战时，唐朝军队一方联军总兵力也没超过三万。再往后面清代乾隆年间平准平回，以及左宗棠收复新疆之时，清军投入兵力也并没有超过汉伐大宛之战。以上还仅仅是对于汉朝一方论述，而从匈奴人在多次会战中仍能重整旗鼓卷土重来的情况来看，说匈奴人处于全民战争也不为过。

第七，汉朝和匈奴的战争持续日久，武帝一朝自马邑之谋开始，两国交兵 40 余年，如果算到公元前 36 年北匈奴郅支单于被杀，也已经经过了近一个世纪。从西汉末期到东汉中期北匈奴最终远遁，则又有超过一个世纪之久。如果上溯到汉朝初年汉军与匈奴首次交战，那么匈奴和汉两个政权之间的战争持续了三个世纪。然而必须指出的是，长期的冲突并没有阻挡两方的交流，漫长的对峙线并不是铁壁铜墙。汉武帝一朝作为汉匈战争的转折点和高峰时期，虽然战争作为具有压倒性的表现形式，但是恰恰是战争本身带来了剧烈的人员和物资交流。汉武帝一朝是双方人员因为被俘和主动投降前往对方国家最多的一个时期，而从史料之中我们显然可以注意到，汉帝国和匈奴都非常注重来归降自己的敌国人员，无不给予富有诚意的优待。我们当然可以认为这是一种宣传上的攻势，但是实际上这些来降人员确实做出了很多工作，有的甚至直接率军与自己曾经的祖国作战，李陵在其中最为著名。对于两国边境地区的民众而言情况更为复杂，例如赵破奴本是九原人，但年轻的时候流亡匈奴，后来才回到汉朝作为汉军将领作战，在一次战败被俘后又在匈奴留居十年归汉；卫律原本是长水的胡人，却为汉朝效力，但是因为害怕卷入汉宫内部的政治事件投降匈奴，成为丁零部落的首领并因为其了解汉朝的胡人身份成为了匈奴人重要的谋主。而像赵信则干脆投降两次，先从匈奴投降汉朝为汉朝作战，然后再次投降匈奴。

两方将领在投诚之后会带来重要的军事信息，匈奴人能够提供给汉人地理信息以及骑兵作战的知识（当然，最主要的肯定是直接参战），而汉人则有助于帮助匈奴人练兵，后者总是容易被忽视。应该指出像李陵这样投降匈奴之后位高权重的汉人降将为匈奴练兵是卓有成效的，例如在匈奴最后击溃李广利军的战斗中，匈奴人居然在夜间通过挖壕沟的方式抵近汉军营寨，进而从汉军背后发动奇袭取胜。这种

通过挖掘壕沟来接近敌军防御工事的办法一直到上个世纪都在军事中被广泛运用，匈奴人打赢了这场迫使汉武帝下《轮台诏》的战争，足见汉朝降将练兵的成效和匈奴人极强的学习能力。正是双方这种在战争中从未间断地互相学习，使得处于弱势的一方总能在一定程度上平衡对方的优势，因而使得战争绵延得更久。除了战场上的俘虏和投降以外，双方互派使者也从来没有长期中断过，而且在两个政权的外交过程中双方都将对方视为能与自己匹敌的对手。例如在漠北决战之后一段时间匈奴人在进行恢复，汉军则忙于在更北的地方修建越来越多的要塞，大型的军事行动暂时停止了。这一短暂的间战期两国通使频繁，而匈奴即使作为前段时期战争的失败者也在外交中极力维护自身尊严和追求对等，例如如果汉朝使臣不放下符节，不用墨涂面，就不允许进入单于的大帐。同时双方互相扣留使节时也追求对等，你扣我一个人，我势必扣你一个人。在周代华夏族这一共同体的观念形成之后，汉朝和匈奴长期交战之前，华夏族实际上并没有一个在实力上足以要求与之对等的敌人，因而华夏人总是可以轻蔑地将周边的异族斥为蛮夷戎狄。

汉匈战争使得这种情况发生了转变，经年累月的与“他者”的对抗将会使双方都增强对于自我的认识，战争促进了两个国家内部的文化认同，特别是作为扭转局势战胜一方的汉族。今天我们在看汉匈战争的历史时，一方面必须承认汉帝国为了打赢这场决定国运的战争，极大地消耗了民力，以至于在汉武帝后期不得不大量征发罪人。但另一方面又很难不注意到当时，汉族知识分子之间的确存在着一种异乎寻常的爱国热情，最典型的证据就是自从与匈奴冲突日频以来，“破奴”“安国”这样充满爱国主义情怀的名字就成为了一个时代的符号。而每次朝廷对匈奴或其余敌人发兵远征，无论征程多么艰险都阻止不了“负私从者”，也就是私人带着粮食跟随军队参战。说这些人是爱国也好，当然更有可能就是为了搏一个军功，毕竟再怎么汉武帝对于军功赏赐的毫不吝啬是全天下都知道的。但无论如何这都说明由于西汉中期特有的社会条件，汉帝国的军事扩张始终存在一定民意基础，这也是为什么在如此遥远的距离如此多次进行人员规模如此庞大的军事调动，而虽有战败而降的将领，但罕有哗变的士卒的原因。

第八，汉朝和匈奴的战争不仅体现在其规模，范围和时间上，而且为整个东亚的军事带来了彻头彻尾的革命，这几乎渗透到了军事的方方面面，包括武器、军事技术、兵种、战术、军制和战略。这种变化符合一般意义上的军事逻辑，当军事冲突越剧烈，规模越大，持续时间越长，在军事上引发的变革就必然越深刻。在这场战争中一些在中国文化意象中占据重要地位的武器装备被淘汰了，以戈和战车为代表，而一些新的明星武器登上历史舞台，以环首刀和汉弩为代表。为了适应不同地区的不同敌人，汉朝军队不得不使用新技术以改良自己的武备，例如在征服南方的过程中面对越人善于潜水的特点，汉朝的内河水师战舰就必须装备防止水下破坏的装置；而为了对抗在北方草原中擅长骑射的匈奴军队，汉朝自己的骑兵就不得不装备更加实用的马具，根据汉代大规模使用骑兵冲击的事实，有理由认为马镫和高马鞍已经得到了一定的使用。而最为重要的军事技术革新则是铁的普及，在武帝统治时期，中华帝国的冶铁技术（特别是高炉炼铁的技术），铁的质量和产量得到了极大的提升，铁制武器基本上普及，军队的防护能力和杀伤能力明显上了一个台阶。作为汉代铁制武器的代表，汉剑不仅成为军队作战时的重要兵器，而且开始在中国的文化中扮演越来越重要的地位，男性贵族佩剑成为一种时尚，乃至成为身份地位的象征。

对骑兵为主体的匈奴军队在匈奴的领地上作战，要求汉军必须具有相称的机动性，因而在卫青和霍去病两位杰出统帅的军事实践中，骑兵大兵团作战的战术成熟起来了，现在中国的军队可以使用骑兵去

打赢一次决定性的会战，而不是让骑兵只作为战争中的配角出现。不仅如此，对匈奴反击的胜利也改变了汉朝长期缺马的现状，在今天祁连山脚下，汉帝国获得了中国历史上最优质也是规模最大的军马场，在今天这里被称作山丹军马场。自从汉武帝征服这里一直到如今，它一直都是全世界规模最大的优质战马来源地之一。畜力的增多对汉军的后勤带来了改善，后来李广利征讨大宛的时候，汉武帝就为其配备了由十几万牛、马、驴、骆驼等牲畜所组成的后勤运输队。除了骑兵作为主力兵种登上历史舞台之外，水军在汉武帝时期，对南方的军事征服中也扮演了骑兵在北方一样的地位。更难能可贵的是，汉帝国并不满足用一支水军仅仅去控制内河航运，而是极为大胆地令其走向海洋，在征服朝鲜的战争中立下武功。也得益于造船技术的发展，中华帝国历史上第一次（部分地）控制了大陆以外的一个大岛，海南岛。为了在频繁的用兵中依然掌握一只直属于皇帝的有力军事力量，汉武帝设置了八校尉，这是汉代募兵制的开始，标志着中国军队职业化水平进一步提高。

最后，汉帝国的军事扩张带来的一个重要结果是中国人第一次掌握了自己生活的土地周边复原几千公里内的山川形势和政权分布情况，这使得中国自从统一以来首次可以制定国家战略。人们现在仍能从中国现在的行政区划和汉代之后的历史事件中看到汉武帝当年卓越的战略眼光。而汉武帝时期最重要的战略方针和战略遗产则是针对北方的强敌匈奴，它在整个古代时期都具备很高的历史意义。针对蒙古高原西高东低，西冷冬暖，西干东湿的自然条件，汉军在反击中将进攻的重点放在了东方，狠狠地打击到了匈奴的心脏地区并在克鲁伦河上游修建了军事防御要塞。在执行这一点的过程中，汉武帝非常注意对于北方胡族进行分化，尤其是蒙古高原腹地的游牧民族和蒙古东部边缘的游牧民族也就是东胡。在命霍去病击破匈奴左地的同时，他也对以乌桓为首的东胡民族施以怀柔政策，设置护乌桓校尉以管理内附的乌桓人，并且特别要求“使其不得与匈奴交通”。汉武帝亲近东胡的政策对中华帝国的历史产生了深远影响，在接下来四个多世纪间，蒙古东部边缘的游牧民族，乌桓和鲜卑人与汉族朝廷之间存在一种亲近的关系，虽然也不是不发生战争，但是更多的时候是以盟友的身份出现。直到西晋末年北方大乱之初，东北方的乌桓人和鲜卑人仍然将刚刚退到江左的东晋政权视为盟友，而去攻击刘渊所率领的匈奴人和石勒所属的羯胡。一旦蒙古和东北地区的少数民族联合起来，或者一个民族据有两地，那么其威胁就会成倍地增长，鲜卑人和满洲人的历史充分证明了这一点。

而在蒙古的西方，汉武帝又意识到蒙古高原和青藏高原的少数民族联合所带来的巨大危险，坚决执行“隔绝羌胡”的战略政策，征服了河西走廊以及河湟地区，进而将大军开进新疆，反过来对匈奴形成一种包围的态势。这一战略在整个历史时期对于稳定中华帝国的西部边疆具有重大意义，武帝之时，青藏高原腹地还并没有强大的政权，羌人也主要是在高原东缘活动。在七个世纪之后，随着吐蕃帝国的快速崛起，汉武帝的战略眼光才跨过漫长的岁月体现出非凡的价值。在吐蕃最如日中天的时候，中唐名臣李泌提出了通过外交联络吐蕃周边各国，特别是要联合已经占据北方草原的回纥共同对抗吐蕃的战略。这一战略取得了巨大的成功，它使得蒙古高原的政权和青藏高原政权相互敌视，保障了唐朝边疆局面的相对安稳，遏制了吐蕃的扩张，并最终拖垮了这个庞大的高原帝国。而明清的蒙古则成为了一个这种战略没有得到良好执行时的相反的例子，在十七世纪，以藏传佛教为纽带，蒙古诸部与西藏之间的联系日益密切，最终在中国西部形成了一个强大的藏传佛教汗国，对清朝产生了严重的威胁。当清帝国经过三代君主几十年的努力最终平定帝国的西疆，就不得不重新审视汉帝国在两千年前的智慧。时至今日，甘肃这一以汉人为主体的狭长省份横亘在新疆、西藏、宁夏、内蒙四个民族自治区之间，将前两者和后两者在地理上完全隔开，其政治意义不言而喻。

第九，汉朝对外战争所带来的不仅是军事上的胜利，除了吞并敌人扩张领土以外，汉代军事扩张带来的最重要收益在于汉人发现并开辟了与外部世界交往的路线。古代东亚总共存在四条与外部世界相交往的主要贸易路线，最北端的一条从蒙古高原沿着欧亚大草原向西串起了这个庞大的游牧地区，其鼎盛时期自然是蒙古征服时期，蒙古帝国的首都哈拉和林最辉煌的年代，它被称为草原丝绸之路。第二条就是经过中国甘肃的河西走廊和新疆东西向的山脉脚下离开今天中国的国境到达中亚，然后再通过伊朗连接更远的西方，这就是现在常说的丝绸之路。第三条是从中国的东南沿海扬帆入海向南航行，最初是拐入暹罗湾穿过克拉地峡，随着航海和造船技术的进步到唐朝开始就已经变为经由马六甲海峡进入印度洋到达印度，以及更远的波斯湾，红海和东非沿海，这就是现在常说的海上丝绸之路。第四条是历史上不同时期四川、云南、西藏等中国南方地区对外连接的通道，以蜀身毒道和茶马古道为代表，现在被称为西南丝绸之路。因为中国在清代之前无法建立对漠北高原的稳定统治，而等到清代的时候随着欧亚大草原的衰退，草原丝绸之路已经不复存在，因而对中华帝国而言意义极有限。剩下三条中华帝国能够控制的对外通道中，陆上丝绸之路和海上丝绸之路均是汉武帝年间通过对外战争和外交活动所打通的，后者当年的起点位于今天广东省的徐闻，汉代叫合浦郡，在被汉帝国征服之前是南越国的领土。而第三条相对不那么重要的西南丝绸之路虽然直到东汉哀牢内附才被视为完全贯通，但是通过汉武帝对西南夷的征伐以及汉帝国在西南地区的道路建设（以博南道为代表），其最终被中华帝国纳入掌控也是时间问题了。

因此，我们可以说，对中原王朝而言有意义的三条对外贸易通道中，汉武帝的军事征服将最重要的两条变为现实，奠定了相对次要的第三条的开通。除了通往西方欧亚大陆的主要部分的道路以外，汉帝国在东北征服朝鲜和频繁巡海的事业促进了东北亚地区的交流和发展，《汉书地理志》里面就曾说乐浪郡海外有倭人时常前来朝贡，这是中国和日本交往的第一次记录，此后则变得越来越常见了。实际上，考古也表明秦汉时期是日本列岛水稻种植技术得到迅速推广的关键时期，日本社会发生了迅速地进步。与外部世界联系的建立不仅将中国人的已知世界扩大了一倍不止，而且也为中国带来了长足的进步。仅以海上丝绸之路为例，为了征服波涛汹涌的南中国海，在汉代诞生了一系列伟大的航海发明，包括平衡式梯形斜帆、船橹和船舵。同时出于定位和海上观测的需要，相关的数学方法也在汉代应运而生，魏晋时期的中国数学家刘徽所写的《海岛算经》中有许多数学问题都来源于海上航行。实际上，虽然被高原山脉所阻隔的东亚仅仅是欧亚大陆相对次要的一部分，但中国所诞生的科学（包括数学）创造论质论量的确在两个时期达到了顶峰，其一就是两汉中期的200余年间，其二就是宋金和元帝国时期。这两个时期的共同特点就是对外交流非常频繁，特别相对于前代而言。毫无疑问，汉武帝时期中国的军事征服不仅仅是扩张领土，同样是中国发现、感受和拥抱世界的过程。

第十，尽管在整个汉代官员文武之分还不明显，但我们仍能注意到，尽管西汉中期进行了如此规模的对外战争，但中央政府始终牢牢掌控了军队。与许多征服帝国不同，汉武帝在进行拓土攘夷的事业时并没有御驾亲征，唯一一次勒兵18万北上邀请单于决战也更多是一种示威，实际上单于也不可能真的来讨这个没趣。汉武帝虽然巡视次数很多，但主要目的地并不是自己所新征服的边疆领地。皇帝年轻的时候就经常率随从打猎搏击，这种爱好伴随了他一生，在其统治后期甚至与百姓一起观看角抵，在高强度的内外压力下仍能有70岁的寿龄足以证明汉武帝本人身体十分健康。可汉帝国的君主已经不需要通过亲临战阵指挥，通过夸示勇武取得军事胜利来巩固自己的统治了。因此我们可以说，帝国的最高决策者在日益远离前线（因为前线一直在向外推进）的宫廷中通过帝国的官僚制度指挥了这场旷世大战。同时，尽管对匈奴的战争使得很多人收获军功进而得到爵位，但即使是如此持久和规模的战争也并没有产生能够对政治起到决定性作用的军事贵族集团，汉朝军队始终在中央政府的控制下，更遑论像罗马军队一样

能够左右帝位的归属。而最终导致西汉终结的人王莽也非出身行伍，反倒是一个外戚身份的大儒，他最终在官僚的支持下以相对平稳的手段篡夺了皇帝之位。